

Royal Mandate of Joan I concerning the Catalan Pirate Bartomeu Pich

Document Summary

Field	Detail
Archival reference	ACA, Cancillería, Reg. [1751?], ff. 131v-132r
Date	Barcelona, 8 May 1387
Issuer	Joan I, King of Aragon (<i>Iohannes etc.</i>)
Recipient	The lieutenant (<i>Gerens vices</i>) of [the Justiciar?] and Governor of the Counties of Roussillon and Cerdagne; the bailiff and other officials of the town of Perpignan; and their lieutenants
Document type	Royal mandate (<i>mandatum</i>) ordering the transfer of a captured prisoner to royal jurisdiction
Language	Latin
Subject	Order to transmit the captive pirate Bartomeu Pich, currently held in the prisons of Perpignan, to the king at Barcelona for trial and punishment for piracy committed against Catalan citizens of Barcelona at sea

Reconciled Transcription

- [1] Iohannes etc. Dilecto Consiliario nostro Gerenti vices Iusticie[?] Gubernator[is] Comitatum Rossilionis
- [2] et Ceritanie ac baiulo seu aliis officialibus Ville Perpinyani et locatenenti[bus] eorundem Salutem et dilectionem.
- [3] Cum nos pro quibusdam iustis causis ad hec animum nostrum rationabiliter inducentibus velimus quod Bartholomeus
- [4] Pich pirata, quem tenetis vestris carceribus mancipatum, qui dudum Cathalanos et alios quamplures
- [5] cives civitatis Barchinone in maribus discurrentes dampnificavit[?], ad nostram Curiam adducatur,
- [6] vobis dicimus et mandamus de certa sciencia et expresse quatenus prefatum Bartholomeum captum ad nos qui

[7] Barchinone personaliter residemus — vobis de dicto Pirata et eius maleficiis plenius noticia

[8] habeatur — sub fidei custodia transmittatis, ut pro delictis per eum commissis penam senciat

[9] quam meretur. Datum Barchinone VIII^a die Madii Anno a nativitate Domini M^o CCC^o LXXX VII^o.

English Translation

John, etc., to our beloved counsellor, the lieutenant of the Justiciar^[1] and Governor of the Counties of Roussillon and Cerdagne,^[2] and to the bailiff and other officials of the town of Perpignan,^[3] and to their lieutenants: greetings and affection.

Whereas we, for certain just reasons reasonably inducing our mind to this end, will that Bartomeu Pich,^[4] pirate,^[5] whom you hold consigned to your prisons, who recently inflicted harm upon^[6] Catalans and very many other citizens of the city of Barcelona^[7] sailing at large in the seas, be brought to our Court — we tell and command you, of certain knowledge and expressly,^[8] that you transmit the aforesaid captive Bartomeu, under faithful custody,^[9] to us, who reside personally in Barcelona^[10] — for fuller notice is had by you concerning the said pirate and his evildoings^[11] — so that for the offenses committed by him he may suffer the penalty he deserves.

Given at Barcelona, the 8th day of May, in the year of the Lord's Nativity 1387.

Footnotes

¹ The compound title in line 1 is genuinely difficult and only partially resolved. The reading is best understood as a vicegerency over two paired offices — the *Iusticia* (Justice/Justiciar) and the *Gubernator* — held by a single deputy. The "lieutenant of [both] the Justiciar and the Governor" (*Gerenti vices [Iusticie et] Gubernatoris*) construction would be consistent with the broader pattern of office-combination under Joan I that recurs in the early registers of his reign. The specific officeholder in May 1387 is not yet identified and has been flagged for prosopographical follow-up. The exact form of the second title element (*Iusticie*, gen. sg., versus *iusticias*, acc. pl., versus another resolution) cannot be settled without higher-resolution examination.

² The Counties of Roussillon and Cerdagne (*Comitatum Rossilionis et Ceritanie*) were administered as a unit under a single governor headquartered at Perpignan. Their integration into the Crown of Aragon's direct administrative orbit, distinct from the Principality of Catalonia proper, is reflected in the way this letter routes through Roussillonese officials rather than the Catalan vicariate.

³ *Ville Perpinyani*: the town of Perpignan, principal urban center of Roussillon and seat of its bailiwick. The bailiff (*baiulus*) of Perpignan is the local royal officer responsible for, among other duties, the custody of prisoners awaiting royal disposition. Pich is in *carceribus* — the town's royal prisons — at the moment the order is drafted.

⁴ *Bartholomeus Pich* (Bartomeu Pich): a pirate operating against Catalan shipping, specifically the citizens of Barcelona. *Pich* is a Catalan family name, and there is nothing in the document to suggest he is anything other than a Christian Catalan subject of the Crown — which is precisely what makes his predation actionable as a domestic criminal matter rather than a corsair conflict with foreign or infidel powers. He has not yet been identified in the secondary literature and is flagged for prosopographical follow-up; figures of the name *Pich* / *Pic* appear with some frequency in Barcelonese mercantile and notarial records of the later fourteenth century.

⁵ *pirata*: in late-fourteenth-century chancery Latin, *pirata* unambiguously denotes a maritime predator operating outside of license. A licensed corsair acting under royal letters of marque would normally be designated *cursarius* or referenced by his commission. The bare designation *pirata* here, combined with the description of his victims as Catalan citizens of Barcelona and the order for trial *ad nostram Curiam*, frames Pich as a criminal subject of the Crown — not a privateer whose excesses are to be adjudicated under different procedure.

⁶ *dampnificavit*[?]: the verb governing the relative clause is the most significant unresolved reading in the document. The visible cluster preserves traces of *D-M-P-O-S* with a macron — most plausibly an abbreviated form of *dampnificavit* ("he caused damage to," "he injured") in the perfect indicative, though the alternative reading *dampnose* (adverb, "ruinously, harmfully") followed by a separate verb cannot be ruled out. Either resolution preserves the substantive sense — Pich's depredations against Catalan shipping — but the precise lexical and syntactic form requires direct manuscript inspection at higher resolution.

⁷ *cives civitatis Barchinone in maribus discurrentes*: "the citizens of the city of Barcelona, sailing at large in the seas." The phrase frames the victims not as cargo or commerce but as *cives* — legal persons whose status as the king's subjects gives Joan jurisdictional standing. *In maribus discurrentes* is a fixed expression in maritime chancery contexts denoting subjects engaged in legitimate sea-traffic; the formula thereby positions Pich's victims as innocent merchants rather than combatants. Piracy against the king's own *cives* is the specific harm that triggers royal jurisdiction over the case.

⁸ *de certa sciencia et expresse*: a fixed chancery formula introducing the operative dispositive clause. The phrase asserts that the king is acting with full knowledge of the relevant facts and with deliberate, explicit will, and is intended to insulate the order from later challenge on procedural or evidentiary grounds. Its presence here, in a routine transfer order, is unsurprising but worth noting because it demonstrates that the chancery treats the transmission of even already-captured prisoners as a juridical act requiring formal protection.

⁹ *sub fidei custodia transmittatis*: "transmit [him] under faithful custody," i.e., under guard sufficient to prevent escape during the journey from Perpignan to Barcelona. Standard formula in royal mandates concerning the transfer of high-profile prisoners; the *fidei* qualifier signals that the transmitting officials remain liable for any escape.

¹⁰ *qui Barchinone personaliter residemus*: "we who reside personally in Barcelona." The royal "we" with the emphatic *personaliter* serves a specific juridical function: it confirms that Pich is being remitted to the king's own person (and therefore to the *Curia regis*) rather than to a Barcelonese officer such as the Vicar or Justiciar of Barcelona. This is consistent with the issuer's location at the date of issue — Joan was indeed in Barcelona on 8 May 1387 — and the king's personal presence converts what could have been a routine local-jurisdiction matter into a case heard under direct royal cognizance.

¹¹ The parenthetical *vobis de dicto Pirata et eius maleficiis plenius noticia habeatur* ("for fuller notice is had by you concerning the said pirate and his evildoings") is the clause's juridical justification for routing the prisoner south rather than dispatching royal officers north to take custody. The Roussillonese officials retain procedural responsibility because they hold the case file — the witness statements, the captured persons or property, the inventories — that any subsequent prosecution will require. The subjunctive *habeatur*, rather than indicative *habetur*, marks the clause as causal-consecutive within the *quatenus*-construction rather than a freestanding statement of fact.

Unresolved Ambiguities

The following items are flagged for archival verification at the manuscript and for further research:

1. **The compound title in line 1** (*Gerenti vices Iusticie[?] Gubernator[is]*). The exact form of the second title element — whether *Iusticie* (gen. sg.), *iusticias* (acc. pl.), or another resolution — is not paleographically settled. The reading "lieutenant of the Justiciar and Governor" is offered as the most plausible reconstruction but should be verified directly. If confirmed, the dual-office construction is of independent interest for the dissertation's argument about office-combination under Joan I.
2. **The verb in line 5** (*dampnificavit[?]*). The cluster preserved as *DMPOS* with a macron most plausibly resolves as a perfect-tense form of *dampnificare* ("to inflict damage upon"), but the alternative reading *dampnose* (adverb) + a following verb cannot be excluded without higher-resolution examination of the manuscript. The substantive sense is unaffected, but the lexical resolution should be settled for the final edition.
3. **The register reference**. The folio numbering (ff. 131v–132r) is preserved from the digitized image filename, but the specific register number (Reg. 1751 or adjacent) should be

confirmed at the manuscript or via the ACA database.

4. Prosopography:

- The lieutenant of the Justiciar/Governor of Roussillon-Cerdagne in May 1387, addressed in line 1, has not yet been identified. The early appointments of Joan I should be checked.
- **Bartomeu Pich:** not yet located in the secondary literature on late-fourteenth-century Catalan piracy or in prosopographical resources for the Pich/Pic family at Barcelona. The case may be locatable in the Llibre del Consell of Barcelona or in the protocol notarial series for the period; given that this is a royal mandate concerning a specific captured pirate, follow-up correspondence (further mandates, judicial proceedings) likely survives in adjacent ACA registers.